Team Leader Interview

Leadership Is Followership

An interview with Roger W. Ferguson Jr.

Former President and CEO of TIAA
Former Vice Chairman of the Federal Reserve



Team 4

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Roger Ferguson is a **purpose-first leader**
who believes **followers** make the leader,
and who leans on a **clear mission** to guide people through crises

1. Personal Leadership: Be someone worth following

You are only a leader if people choose to follow

1 Start with followership

He calls leadership “all about engendering followership.” Without followers, whether 2 people or 2 million, you may be a good analyst, but not a leader.

2 Four things earn followers

Expertise, explaining where you are going, empathy, and fortitude, unchanged across his career. What shifts is cultural expertise: its language and organization.

> *“a cultural expertise of how do you get things done in a company”*

3 Ask for help

People imagine leaders as “nearly perfect gods,” but a leader “can get practically nothing done” alone. Part of leadership is knowing when and whom to ask.

Our analysis

He builds credibility by showing both capability and limits.

Course connection

Expertise and direction show wisdom and vision; fortitude shows courage; asking for help signals authenticity.

2. Relational Leadership: No one is a cog

Accessibility builds trust and helps the truth travel upward

1 **Make yourself approachable**

Getting his own lunch and stopping to ask employees questions made conversations with the CEO feel normal.

2 **Listen beyond the hierarchy**

He spoke directly with employees who knew the details and used town halls to encourage dialogue.

> *"The person who's one level below you is probably four levels above the person who actually knows the detail."*

3 **Give every voice value**

He emphasized listening and respect regardless of position or background.

Our analysis

These behaviors illustrate how respect and listening build trust.

Course connection

That trust can make people more willing to share details that might otherwise be filtered through the hierarchy.

3. Contextual Leadership: In confusion, stay true to the mission

A clear mission turned uncertain crisis into solvable problems

1 **Set the North Star in the middle of the 9/11 crisis**

With no one sure why the World Trade Center was burning, he set the uncertainty aside and reminded the Fed why it exists.

2 **Sent one consistent message**

At 9:45am and again near noon, the Fed said the same thing: it is open, operating, and will supply liquidity.

> *"All of it basically said the same thing, which is the Fed is open and operating, and we'll use our various tools to create sufficient liquidity."*

3 **Used the mission to make close calls**

His test for every hard decision: does this raise or lower our chance of achieving the mission?

Our analysis

In a crisis, the leader can't make every call. A shared mission lets people decide the way the leader would.

Course connection

Contextual leadership clarifies a team's purpose, bringing coherence and focus in times of confusion.

4. Supportive Leadership: Fix the problem, not the blame

Create a culture where people feel safe to bring problems forward

1 **Set the expectation**

He told people he wants bad news to “take the elevator.” People have a hard time believing it, so you have to consistently remind them.

2 **Don't kill the messenger**

He moderates his response, because whatever his response was, it got amplified as the person retold the story.

3 **Turn it into solutions**

The natural tendency is to ask what happened and who caused it. He asks how to think about resolving it

4 **Why it Matters**

People who bring bad news are afraid of the blame process; demotion, being fired, not getting a bonus. He wants them in a "Problem-solving psychology" before a defensive one. A culture of inclusion "gives everyone more agency to sit at the table and lean in."

Our analysis

He builds a supportive culture by focusing on solutions rather than blame, which create psychological safety and encourages people to bring problem forward early.

Course connection

Psychological Safety and inclusion increase engagement and give people more agency, leading to better decision-making and faster problem resolution.

5. Responsible Leadership: Stewardship through balance

Long-term stewardship requires short-term pain to preserve trust

1 **Protect participants' long-term security**

Preserving TIAA's financial health and AAA rating protected participants' life savings and their confidence in the institution.

2 **Accept a tactical trade-off (2008)**

The rating agency asked TIAA to validate marked asset values in an illiquid market. Ferguson sold a small position despite expecting its value to recover, preserving trust in TIAA's risk systems.

> *"You can't go out and ask people for their life savings a second time."*

3 **Replace checklists with a priority hierarchy**

Rather than using static checklists, Ferguson ranks core values in advance so teams know what yields when priorities collide.

Our analysis

He accepts near-term costs to protect trust over decades.

Course connection

Responsible leadership balances immediate decisions with long-term obligations. Clear priorities guide execution when values collide.

Thank You